

Men, menopause and the great silence

Somewhere in the grand **script** of human relationships, an entire chapter has been written in **whispers, behind closed doors**, between women who **nod** in knowing silence. It is a chapter that speaks of **hot flashes** and mood swings, of **fatigue** that **seeps into** the bones and emotions that rise like tidal waves.

This chapter is titled 'Menopause' — and, quite **conspicuously**, it has very few male readers. Menopause is still a largely private, female conversation. Men are so **often** kept outside its boundaries, or worse, they willingly exclude themselves from it. Pray tell us, why. **The answer**, like many things **woven** into cultural conditioning, **lies in a mix of** ignorance, discomfort, and a **longstanding** belief that women's bodily changes are theirs alone to **endure**. But **therein lies** the irony.

Menopause is not just about women. It is about marriages, relationships, workplaces, and families. It affects dynamics beyond the woman experiencing it, yet men remain **unversed** in its realities. In a world where **gender parity** is a constant conversation, how is it that a physiological **transition** that impacts half the human race remains a blind spot for the other half? Why is menopause rarely spoken about between husbands and wives, brothers and sisters, fathers and daughters? How many men, I **wonder**, can truly claim to understand what menopause **entails** beyond the **cursory** knowledge that it **marks** the end of a woman's reproductive years? Menopause is not **merely** a biological event, it is a **seismic** shift in a woman's body and mind. It brings with it a **cascade** of symptoms — sleepless nights, brain fog, anxiety, depression, and a sense of **alienation** from one's own body.

It is **unpredictable**. It is **relentless**. It is often endured in silence because the world around her, particularly the men in her life, do not know how to engage with it. I **presume the exclusion** of men from the menopause conversation **is** not a **deliberate conspiracy**, but a result of years of social conditioning. Men have not been encouraged to ask, to understand, or to offer support. Women, on the other hand, have not always felt comfortable sharing, either out of a sense of **resignation** or out of fear that their struggles will be met with **awkwardness** or **dismissal**. It is not uncommon for a woman battling the emotional and physical **toll** of menopause to hear her **distress** being **brushed aside** with phrases like, "It's just a phase," or "Everyone goes through it." This is not because men are **inherently indifferent**, but because they have not been made a part of the narrative.

They have not been **equipped with** the language to **empathise**, nor have they been told that their understanding could make a **profound** difference. Imagine a world where men are as **attuned to** menopause as they are to pregnancy.

Imagine a world where fathers talk to their daughters about it, where husbands don't just tolerate but actively support their wives through it. Imagine a workplace where male bosses recognise that a sudden drop in performance could be due to menopause — **induced** fatigue rather than **incompetence**. Such a world is possible, but it requires a shift, a willingness to break the silence and

bring men into the fold. The question, then, is how do we **bridge this gap**? How do we make menopause as much a men's issue as it is a woman's? The first step is to talk — **boldly**, openly, and without **embarrassment**. Women must shed the fear of being seen as weak or **hysterical** and share their experiences **candidly**. Men must listen, not with the intent to 'fix' but to understand. Schools must **incorporate** menopause education alongside **puberty** discussions.

Workplaces must **foster** policies that recognise its impact. And most importantly, society must stop treating menopause as a women's private burden and recognise it as a life stage that affects families and communities as a whole. Menopause is not a disease. It is not an **aberration**. It is as natural as adolescence and just as transformative. And yet, the world gives it none of the space or respect it deserves. It is time for that to change. It is time for men to step forward, not as **mere bystanders**, but as **allies** in a journey that every **woman** — wife, mother, sister, friend — **will inevitably** take. For too long, menopause has been spoken of in **hushed** tones, if at all. But silence can never be a remedy for understanding. Conversations, however, have the power to change and improve lives. Let us start this one today.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Menopause** (noun) – The time of life when a woman's ovaries stop producing hormones and menstrual periods stop
2. **Script** (noun) – Narrative, Story, Framework, Blueprint, Plan कथानक
3. **Whisper** (noun) – Murmur, Mumble, Hint, Trace, Suggestion फुसफुसाहट
4. **Behind closed doors** (phrase) – Privately, Secretly, In camera, Confidential, In private गोपनीय रूप से
5. **Nod** (noun) – Gesture, Signal, Indication, Acknowledgement, Approval सिर हिलाना
6. **Hot flash** (noun) – A sudden, temporary onset of body warmth, flushing, and sweating
7. **Fatigue** (noun) – Exhaustion, Weariness, Tiredness, Lethargy, Burnout थकान
8. **Seep** (into) – (verb) – Permeate, Infiltrate, Penetrate, Ooze, Trickle रिसना
9. **Conspicuously** (adverb) – Noticeably, Prominently, Obviously, Clearly, Markedly स्पष्ट रूप से
10. **Often** (adverb) – Frequently, Regularly, Repeatedly, Commonly, Habitually अक्सर
11. **Weave** (verb) – Intertwine, Blend, Integrate, Incorporate, Braid बुनना
12. **In a mix of** (phrase) – Combination, Blend, Fusion, Amalgam, Composite मिश्रण में
13. **Longstanding** (adjective) – Chronic, Persistent, Established, Enduring, Longterm दीर्घकालिक
14. **Endure** (verb) – Bear, Suffer, Withstand, Tolerate, Survive सहन करना
15. **Therein lies** (phrase) – In that place, In that fact, There exists, That contains उसमें निहित है
16. **Irony** (noun) – Paradox, Contradiction, Incongruity, Absurdity, Twist विडंबना
17. **Unversed** (adjective) – Unfamiliar, Ignorant, Uninformed, Naive, Untrained अनभिज्ञ
18. **Gender parity** (noun) – Equality, Equity, Balance, Equal representation लैंगिक समानता
19. **Transition** (noun) – Change, Shift, Passage, Transformation, Conversion परिवर्तन
20. **Wonder** (verb) – Ponder, Question, Marvel, Speculate, Doubt सोचना
21. **Entail** (verb) – Involve, Require, Necessitate, Demand, Include शामिल करना

22. **Cursory** (adjective) – Superficial, Perfunctory, Brief, Hasty, Casual सतही
23. **Mark** (verb) – Indicate, Signify, Denote, Represent, Signal चिह्नित करना
24. **Merely** (adverb) – Only, Simply, Just, Barely, Solely केवल
25. **Seismic** (adjective) – having a very great effect; of very great size
26. **Cascade** (noun) – Waterfall, Torrent, Flood, Avalanche, Chain reaction झरना
27. **Alienation** (noun) – Estrangement, Isolation, Detachment, Distance, Separation अलगाव
28. **Unpredictable** (adjective) – Erratic, Uncertain, Variable, Capricious, Random अप्रत्याशित
29. **Relentless** (adjective) – Persistent, Unremitting, Inexorable, Unyielding, Unrelenting निरंतर
30. **Presume** (verb) – Assume, Suppose, Deduce, Infer, Guess मान लेना
31. **Deliberate** (adjective) – Intentional, Calculated, Conscious, Purposeful, Planned जानबूझकर
32. **Conspiracy** (noun) – Plot, Scheme, Collusion, Machination, Intrigue साजिश
33. **Resignation** (noun) – Acceptance, Submission, Acquiescence, Compliance, Endurance स्वीकृति
34. **Awkwardness** (noun) – Unease, Discomfort, Clumsiness, Embarrassment, Stiffness अजीबता
35. **Dismissal** (noun) – Rejection, Disregard, Neglect, Repudiation, Denial खारिज करना
36. **Toll** (noun) – Cost, Price, Consequence, Effect, Impact प्रभाव
37. **Distress** (noun) – Anguish, Suffering, Pain, Torment, Agony संकट
38. **Brush aside** (phrasal verb) – Dismiss, Ignore, Disregard, Overlook, Neglect नज़रअंदाज़ करना
39. **Inherently** (adverb) – Naturally, Intrinsically, Essentially, Fundamentally, Innately स्वाभाविक रूप से
40. **Indifferent** (adjective) – Apathetic, Unconcerned, Detached, Disinterested, Unmoved उदासीन
41. **Equip** (with) – (verb) – Provide, Furnish, Supply, Arm, Prepare सुसज्जित करना
42. **Empathise** (verb) – Understand, Relate, Sympathize, Comprehend, Connect सहानुभूति रखना
43. **Profound** (adjective) – Deep, Intense, Significant, Thoughtful, Farreaching गहरा

44. **Attune** (to) – (verb) – Adjust, Adapt, Accustom, Familiarize, Harmonize
अनुकूलित करना
45. **Induce** (verb) – Cause, Bring about, Generate, Provoke, Stimulate उत्पन्न करना
46. **Incompetence** (noun) – Ineptitude, Inability, Incapability, Inadequacy, Unfitness अक्षमता
47. **Bring someone into fold** (phrase) – Include, Incorporate, Welcome, Integrate, Embrace शामिल करना
48. **Bridge the gap** (phrase) – Connect, Reconcile, Narrow, Link, Unite अंतर कम करना
49. **Boldly** (adverb) – Courageously, Bravely, Confidently, Fearlessly, Audaciously साहसपूर्वक
50. **Embarrassment** (noun) – Shame, Discomfort, Humiliation, Awkwardness, Unease शर्मिंदगी
51. **Hysterical** (adjective) – Overemotional, Frenzied, Panicky, Uncontrolled, Irrational उन्मत्त
52. **Candidly** (adverb) – Frankly, Openly, Honestly, Directly, Bluntly स्पष्ट रूप से
53. **Incorporate** (verb) – Include, Integrate, Absorb, Assimilate, Combine शामिल करना
54. **Puberty** (noun) – Adolescence, Teenage years, Development, Maturation, Youth यौवनावस्था
55. **Foster** (verb) – Encourage, Promote, Nurture, Cultivate, Support बढ़ावा देना
56. **Aberration** (noun) – Anomaly, Deviation, Irregularity, Exception, Oddity विचलन
57. **Mere** (adjective) – Simple, Bare, Basic, Pure, Just केवल
58. **Bystander** (noun) – Onlooker, Spectator, Observer, Witness, Viewer दर्शक
59. **Ally** (noun) – Supporter, Partner, Associate, Collaborator, Friend सहयोगी
60. **Inevitably** (adverb) – Unavoidably, Certainly, Inescapably, Necessarily, Surely अनिवार्य रूप से
61. **Hushed** (adjective) – Quiet, Subdued, Muted, Whispered, Soft शांत

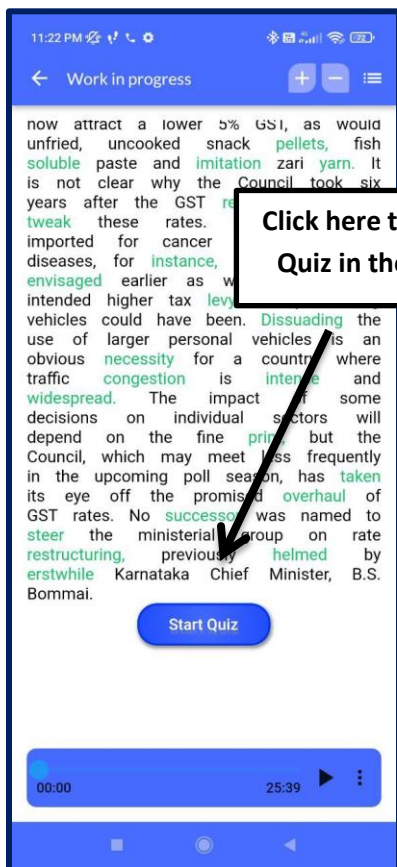
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Silent Suffering:** Menopause is often discussed privately among women, with men largely excluded from the conversation.
2. **Male Disengagement:** Men remain uninformed about menopause due to ignorance, discomfort, and societal conditioning.
3. **Broader Impact:** Menopause affects not just women but also marriages, workplaces, and family dynamics.
4. **Gender Parity Paradox:** Despite discussions on gender equality, menopause remains a blind spot for men.
5. **Lack of Dialogue:** Few men understand menopause beyond its basic definition as the end of reproductive years.
6. **Physical & Emotional Toll:** Symptoms include hot flashes, insomnia, anxiety, depression, and cognitive struggles.
7. **Endured Alone:** Women often suffer in silence because men don't know how to engage with the issue.
8. **Social Conditioning:** Men aren't encouraged to learn or support, and women hesitate to share their struggles.
9. **Dismissive Attitudes:** Men often downplay menopause with phrases like "It's just a phase," lacking empathy.
10. **Need for Empathy:** Men must be included in the narrative and equipped to understand and support.
11. **Ideal World Vision:** Men should be as informed about menopause as they are about pregnancy.
12. **Workplace Awareness:** Employers should recognize menopause-related challenges affecting performance.
13. **Breaking the Silence:** Open, honest conversations are needed—women sharing experiences, men listening without judgment.
14. **Education & Policy:** Schools and workplaces must integrate menopause awareness into discussions and policies.

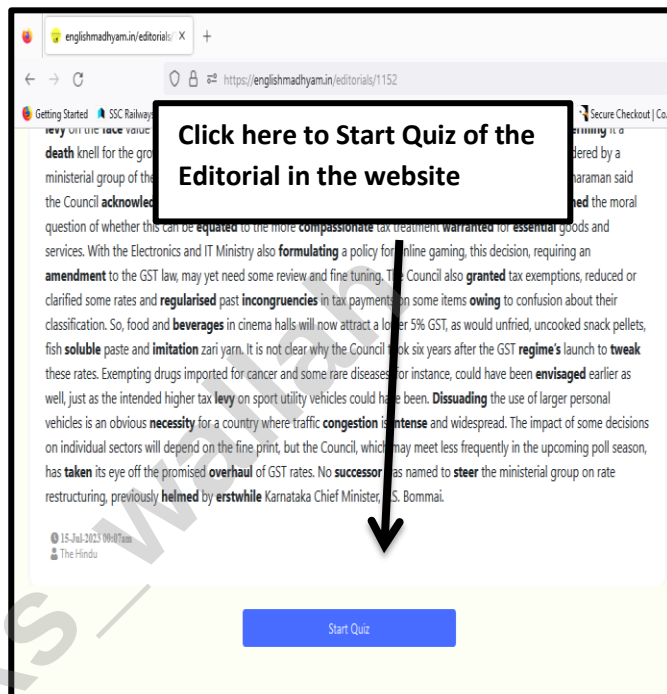
15. **Collective Responsibility:** Menopause is a natural life stage; men must step up as allies, not bystanders.

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Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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